

One Foot Island

Tour Guide · Aitutaki, Cook Islands

About the Island

One Foot Island (local name: **Tapuaetai**) is a small uninhabited motu (islet) in the Aitutaki Lagoon in the Cook Islands. It sits on the southeastern side of the lagoon, about 7 km from the main island of Aitutaki.

The island is famous for its powder-white sand, clear turquoise water, and a few palm trees. It is one of the most photographed spots in the South Pacific and is often ranked among the world's best beaches. You can walk around the whole island in about 15–20 minutes.

Its English name comes from a local legend: a father carried his son while fleeing enemies, leaving only one set of footprints in the sand.

Quick Facts

Location	Aitutaki Lagoon, Cook Islands (South Pacific)
Size	About 570 m long and up to 210 m wide
Type	Uninhabited sandy motu with white sand and palms
Famous for	Turquoise lagoon, passport stamp, snorkelling
Access	By boat only (lagoon cruise or private charter)

Best Time to Visit

The best period is the **dry season: May to October**. The weather is more stable, seas are calmer, and the lagoon water is clearer for swimming and snorkelling.

The Cook Islands are warm year-round. November to April is the wetter season and also the cyclone season, so travel can be more uncertain.

How to Get There

You can only reach One Foot Island by boat. There is no road or bridge.

1. Lagoon Cruise (Most Popular)

- Almost every visitor comes on a half-day or full-day lagoon cruise from Aitutaki.
- Cruises usually leave in the morning and stop at One Foot Island for swimming, snorkelling, and a BBQ lunch.
- Common operators include Bishop's Cruises, Schofield's Wet & Wild, and The Vaka Cruise.
- Book through your hotel or in advance — places can fill up in peak season.

2. Private Boat / Water Taxi

- Ask your accommodation to arrange a private boat for a more flexible or quieter visit.
- This allows you to stay longer or visit outside the main cruise times (when the island is busier).

Getting to Aitutaki First

- Fly into Rarotonga (main international airport of the Cook Islands).
- Then take a short domestic flight (about 45–50 minutes) to Aitutaki Airport.

What to Do

- **Swim and snorkel** in the calm, clear lagoon water.
- **Walk around the island** — it only takes 15–20 minutes.
- **Get your passport stamped** at the small post office (often called the world's smallest or most remote post office on an uninhabited island). Bring your passport!
- Send a postcard from the island post office.
- Relax on the white sand and enjoy the views of the lagoon.

What to Bring

- Passport (for the special stamp)
- Sunscreen, hat, and sunglasses
- Water and snacks (unless your cruise includes lunch)
- Swimwear and a towel
- Snorkel gear (some tours provide it)
- Cash for postcards or small purchases
- Reef-safe sunscreen and a bag for rubbish

Facilities

The island is uninhabited. There is a small post office hut that opens for cruise visitors, and some basic shade. There are no hotels, restaurants, or running water. Most people come on organised tours that provide lunch and facilities on the boat.

Useful Tips

1. Bring your passport if you want the special One Foot Island stamp.
2. Book your lagoon cruise early, especially in peak season.
3. The island gets busiest around lunchtime when most cruise boats arrive.
4. For a quieter experience, try a private boat earlier or later in the day.
5. Protect the environment — take all rubbish with you.
6. The water is usually calm and shallow, good for most swimmers.

Information compiled for 2026. Always check current cruise schedules and conditions with local operators.

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